

Glossary

Aerial perspective

Also *atmospheric perspective* – a method of creating illusions of depth or recession in which colours become weaker and bluer with distance.

Aesthetics

Derived from the Greek word 'aesthesis' meaning perception, this describes what makes something beautiful or ugly.

Anthropomorphic

Something that is not human given human aspects or attributes.

Bodegóns

In Spanish art, a painting set in a kitchen or tavern, often including one or more figures. From the Spanish *bodega*, meaning 'pantry', 'tavern', or 'wine cellar'.

Bourgeoisie

The middle class of society, often considered to be led by materialism and a concern for respectability and social advancement.

Collage

A technique in which pieces of paper, photographs, fabric and other materials are glued on a support to create pictures or patterns, and also the resulting work of art.

Contrapposto

An Italian term meaning counter-pose, used to describe a figure standing with most weight on one foot, and the shoulders and arms twisting in the opposite direction to the hips and legs.

Foreshortening

Distorted depictions of things to convey dramatic perspective.

Fresco

A mural painting technique using water-based paint. *Buon fresco* is painting on to wet plaster so the paint becomes an integral part of the wall, and *fresco secco* is painting on to dry walls.

Ground

Usually a preliminary coating or priming for a drawing or painting on a support such as canvas or panel.

Hieroglyphics

A form of writing, especially of ancient Egypt, in which pictures and symbols are used to represent objects, ideas, or sounds

Humanism

A form of thought that makes people the first consideration as a basis for philosophical enquiry.

Iconoclasm

The wilful destruction of religious imagery and icons.

Iconography

Types of imagery used by artists to convey particular meanings. For example, in Christian painting, the dove representing the Holy Spirit.

Illusionistic

Artists' attempts to represent the visual world, to create the appearance of three-dimensions on flat, two-dimensional surfaces.

Life drawing

The drawing of live, usually nude, human models – an important part of much formal artistic training.

Linear perspective

Drawing or painting three-dimensional illusions on two-dimensional surfaces, primarily using line. Objects far away become smaller and receding parallel lines appear to converge on the horizon.

Meander

A decorative border made from a continuous geometric line, repeatedly turning back on itself – also called the Greek fret or key pattern.

Motif

A dominant or recurring idea in a work or an artist's oeuvre.

Movable type

A system of printing and typography that uses movable, reusable components to reproduce symbols.

Narrative

Art that tells a story, either as a moment in a story, or as a sequence of events.

Painterly

The application of paint in a loose, free manner, leaving visible brushstrokes in the finished painting.

Readymades

A term first used by Marcel Duchamp to describe works of art made from previously manufactured objects.

Reliefs

A kind of carving or sculpture raised from a flat background, like a three-dimensional picture. High and low (or bas) relief refers to the depth of protrusion.

Stucco

Fine plaster used for coating wall surfaces or moulding into architectural decorations.

Theosophy

A religious philosophy popular in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, incorporating aspects of Buddhism and Brahmanism.

Tronies

Types of portraits often involving costume-wearing, used by artists as studies of expression, type, appearance, or characters.

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